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IN THE FINAL DAYS before the election in New Hampshire, I think almost everybody except the other candidates agreed that the primary had settled down to a race between George Bush and myself, with Bush the front runner.

When the *Nashua Telegraph* offered to sponsor a debate between the two of us on the Saturday evening preceding the election, we both accepted. Understandably, this brought howls from the other candidates. In protest, one of them, Senator Bob Dole, complained to the Federal Elections Commission that by financing a debate between only two of the seven candidates, the newspaper was making an illegal campaign contribution to the Bush and Reagan campaigns.

The commission agreed with him. Rather than scrap the scheduled debate, we suggested to the Bush camp that the two of us split the cost of holding it. After the Bush people turned down our proposal, we offered to pay the full cost of the debate—a few thousand dollars—and they accepted.

I thought it had been unfair to exclude from the debate the other candidates, most of whom were also campaigning in New Hampshire that weekend, and since we were now sponsoring and paying for it, I decided to invite them to join the debate; four of the other candidates—Bob Dole, Howard Baker, John Anderson, and Phil Crane (John Connally was campaigning elsewhere)—accepted.

When we walked on to a platform set up for the debate at the Nashua High School gymnasium Saturday night, there was one table, two chairs, and six candidates.

When he spotted the four other candidates, Jim Baker, George Bush's campaign manager, protested and said